

Overview: Backward Chaining

Backward chaining flips traditional teaching on its head. Instead of starting at the beginning and gradually building up, you complete most of the task FOR the pupil, then let them do just the final step. Once they've mastered that, you leave the last TWO steps for them. Then three. The pupil always ends by completing the task themselves, building confidence and muscle memory from the end backward. This is particularly powerful for pupils who give up early because they've never experienced finishing something.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil starts tasks but rarely completes them
- Says "I can't do it" before really trying
- Gives up when the task gets difficult early on
- Has no experience of independent completion

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Pick a sequential task

Choose a task with clear, ordered steps that the pupil regularly fails to complete. Writing tasks, maths procedures, and daily routines work well.

Teacher says: N/A - this is prep

Tip: The task must have a defined end point. Creative or open-ended tasks don't suit backward chaining.

2 Do a task analysis

Break the task into every individual step from start to finish. Write these down so you know exactly where to hand over.

Tip: For a paragraph: topic sentence, evidence, explanation. For packing up: close book, put in bag, zip bag, stand, push chair in.

3 Complete all steps except the last

Do the earlier steps yourself, or guide the pupil hand-over-hand. Don't make a fuss about it - just get there efficiently.

Teacher says: "Right, I've done the first parts. Now you finish it."

Tip: If possible, pre-prepare templates so this doesn't take lesson time.

4 Cue the final step

Use a simple, consistent phrase to hand over. The pupil completes just the last step.

Teacher says: "Now you finish it." or "Just this last step - you do it."

Tip: Keep the cue the same every time so it becomes automatic.

5 Celebrate completion

Acknowledge that they finished the task. Not effusively - just genuinely. The completion is the reward.

Teacher says: "You finished it. The whole thing is done because you finished it."

6 Add steps backward over time

Once the last step is fluent (automatic, not just accurate), leave the last two steps. Keep working backward.

Teacher says: "Tomorrow we'll leave a bit more for you."

Tip: Some pupils need days or weeks on a single step. That's fine. Patience is key.

English Example: Writing a PEE Paragraph

Year 9 writing a Point-Evidence-Explanation paragraph about Macbeth. Pupil working at KS1 level finds the three-part structure overwhelming.

Week 1: Explanation only

Teacher: Writes Point and Evidence. Says: "I've written that Lady Macbeth is ambitious, with a quote. Now you write why this shows ambition. Start with 'This shows...'"

Pupil: Writes one sentence starting with "This shows..."

Celebrate completion

Teacher: Says: "You finished the paragraph. Read the whole thing - you wrote that ending."

Pupil: Reads complete paragraph aloud. Sees their contribution.

Week 2: Evidence + Explanation

Teacher: Writes Point only. Says: "I've written the point. Now you find a quote and explain it."

Pupil: Selects quote from options. Writes Evidence and Explanation.

Week 3: Full paragraph

Teacher: Provides scaffold only. Says: "Now write all three parts."

Pupil: Writes complete PEE paragraph with scaffold support.

Maths Example: Multi-step percentage problem

Year 8 calculating sale prices. Problem: A jacket costs 80 pounds with a 25% discount. What's the sale price? This requires finding 25% of 80, then subtracting.

Day 1: Final calculation only

Teacher: Calculates 25% of $80 = 20$. Says: "I've worked out that 25% of 80 is 20. That's the discount. Now you finish it - what's 80 minus 20?"

Pupil: Writes $80 - 20 = 60$. Says "60 pounds."

Celebrate completion

Teacher: Says: "The sale price is 60 pounds. You solved the problem."

Pupil: Sees they completed a two-step percentage problem.

Day 2: Both calculations

Teacher: Shows how to find 25% (divide by 4). Says: "Find 25% of 80, then subtract it."

Pupil: Calculates $80 / 4 = 20$, then $80 - 20 = 60$.

Science Example: Writing a conclusion

Year 7 writing a conclusion for a plant growth experiment. A proper conclusion has three parts: what we tested, what we found, and what it means.

Week 1: Meaning only

Teacher: Writes what was tested and what was found. Says: "I've written that we tested light versus dark and that the light plant grew more. Now you write the final sentence - what does this tell us? Start with 'This shows that...'"

Pupil: Writes: "This shows that plants need light to grow."

Celebrate completion

Teacher: Says: "You've finished the conclusion."

Pupil: Sees their sentence completes a proper scientific conclusion.

Week 2: Findings + Meaning

Teacher: Writes what was tested only. Says: "You write what we found and what it means."

Pupil: Writes two sentences about findings and meaning.

Week 3: Full conclusion

Teacher: Provides sentence starters only.

Pupil: Writes complete three-part conclusion.